

Echo and Narcissus

"... She comes and goes. / Each morning it is her face that replaces the darkness. / In me she has drowned a young girl, and in me an old woman / Rises toward her day after day, like a terrible fish."

Sylvia Plath, *Mirror*

She hadn't chosen him, he just appeared and she had tracked, orientating towards him like a plant following the sun. A helpless and complete turning. A pull so strong it ached in her. She had tried to look away. To leave. To sit with other people. But she was always drawn to hover in the dimness and exult at his light, dragged back by something that couldn't be denied.

And here she was now, looking at the two young women at the end of the bar; they were leaning towards him, not bothering to pretend anymore. She watched from afar as she sat with a drink in the shadows.

She knew what these women were, she had watched their predecessors for thirty years. Laughing, baring red rimmed teeth they trailed their particular lures across the waters with an easy confidence.

Touching his arm to make a point one might leave with him. Never to return. Back to his apartment. She had stopped counting how many times.

He was her main focus, as always. Thirty years and it had always been him. She wanted him as much as ever, never wanted anybody else. Her need was an exquisite pain in her chest, a stubborn vice like squeezing of her heart, it never eased, never allowed another, she was fifty-three years old and she loved him as much now as when she was twenty-three.

He didn't even know her name.

Or so she thought for a long time. He knew her, the way you know a piece of furniture you've lived around for years, familiar, the old leather chair at a wine bar, it will always just be there, its absence not considered. She was now part of the texture of his evenings, a shadow at the edge of his night. She had learned that this was not nothing. But she had also learned it was not enough.

His hands moved as he talked, shaping the air. The two young women laughed. His eyes followed his hands, caught in his own conjuring, building a surface he couldn't stop looking at, private and enchanted, an allure of the self.

It was his hands she loved the most. His veins more prominent these days, skin loose at the knuckles, showing the real him under the veil he had constructed. She found them beautiful in the way things are beautiful when they've been used and worn in. What would it be like she wondered,

longed for, to have those hands reach for her. Not in the half-hearted way they did at the end of the night when everyone younger had gone home, but with a knowing, an actual knowing of her.

She lifted her glass, and watched, and waited, as she always did.

By the second hour she had drifted closer to him, a leaf floating on subtle currents. He was holding court at the end of the bar. There were three or four people perched around him, arranged like pilot fish tasting the waters. She took a bar stool close by, so she could hear his voice, but be far enough away to become part of the background. A texture of the shadows.

He was talking about the view of the harbour from his apartment, his pitch, his invitation. The bobbing boats, the ferries trailing sparkling bubbles, the light off the water projecting on itself like a mirror.

"The way everything becomes just a mirror of itself," he said, his hands gesturing.

"A mirror of itself" she sighed softly.

She said the words the way she always did, lifted from his mouth to hers, returned to him like light refracted through water. He didn't notice, he was already somewhere else in his story.

One of the young women leaned forward, laughed and touched his arm. She felt a quick intake of pain, a sucking pulse of pressure, like a door closing in a house and the atmosphere changing. He flicked his hand through the air as if in a Parisian restaurant, "Barman, another one for this lovely lady."

She sat with his words in her mouth, the harbour, the light, the mirror of itself, and felt the old tug of ache and regret. This was all she had. The returning of these things over and over through the years. The shape of his thoughts in her own mimicking, worn smooth with use, like stones the sea has rolled and turned for a very long time. She signaled the barman for another drink.

"Another one for this lovely lady" she whispered.

By midnight he had made his choice and it wasn't her.

She watched him helping the tottering woman in the silver dress with her coat, and then they were gone, and the room was just a room again, the bar just a place to drink.

She finished her drink. Then she ordered another. Then, sometime after one, her phone lit up with his name. She peered down at it with trembling fingers, the sap fleeing her wrinkled flesh, and with a fluttering touch she taps and her heart whispers, "Another one for this lovely lady".

The mirror was the first thing you saw.

It was huge and consumed the whole of the ceiling. Vast and gilt-edged. She didn't look up, she had looked up at it more times than she could count, and it still struck her as both absurd and magnificent.

But she did look up, she always eventually looks up, and the mirror always looks back down on her.

He was awake already and lay on his back, with an intense stillness, like a statue carved from Parian marble. He was engrossed, devotional, in the private act of roving his eyes over himself, his gleaming image dancing magically before him.

She turned on her side, tracing his profile with her thoughts.

She studied him looking at himself and felt, as she always had, the deep tenderness of it and the absurdity, the sheer vanity of his obsession, but beneath it all, his touching need.

He was beautiful. She couldn't pretend otherwise, not even to herself, not even now. He still made her breath catch.

His shoulders were broad against the crisp white sheets, his jaw still strong in profile, his movements last night showed the slow confidence of a man entirely at home in his own body. But she could see what the mirror chose not to show him, or what he chose not to see. The silver threading through his chest hair, the slackening around his jaw, the hands, lying at ease on the sheets, their years written in every line and fold. The reflection that pleased him so completely was a lie. A chimera. They both marveled at it together. Only one of them knew the truth.

A single tear fell from his eye. She saw the pain and bliss he holds in equal parts during this morning ritual. He was in love, the strangest longing in a lover; himself. For just a moment, the veil is lifted, and it seems like he looks into his dazzling reflection and sees his true self revealed. An aging man consumed by an unnatural love. But the moment passes and maybe it wasn't really there at all.

But something was different this morning. The tear doesn't dry. His hands, those beautiful hands, moved toward his face and then stopped, as though uncertain of their purpose. The reflection above him wavered, and for a long moment he lay there not with the expression of a man enchanted but of a man slowly, terribly awaking.

She has seen this look before, or she thinks she has. A slight crack in the surface. A rippling tear in his grasping veneer. A glimpse of the water beneath.

She waited, shallow breathing.

"I'm tired," he said. Not to her. To the ceiling. To the mirror. To whatever it was he saw there. His voice was very quiet and had in it something she'd never heard before, a raw bewildered note, like a man who has walked a long way and can't remember why.

She did not return his words to him this time.

For thirty years she had given him back himself, his phrases, his light refracted and returned. But something in her had shifted in the long hours of the night. She had lain beside him in the dark and felt a loosening of something that had been held in her chest since she was twenty-three. Not the love that was still there, a permanent breath in her, but the helplessness. The waiting. The assumption that she had no words of her own to offer.

She reached out and placed her hand over his. His fingers, those extraordinary fingers, turned and held hers with a grip that surprised her, uncertain, almost afraid.

"I see you," she said. For the first time. Her words her own.

She waited for him to find his.